

ping too—Lachlan Murdoch's company Illyria bought into Jaipur franchise with UK-based Emerging Media.

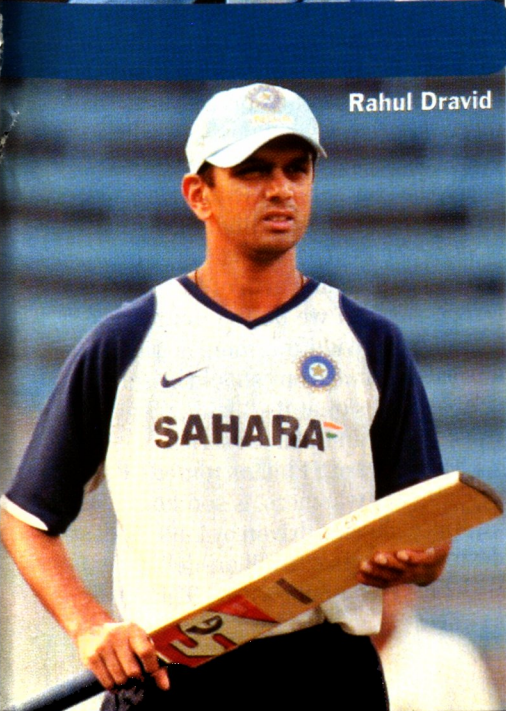
Cricket has seen nothing like this. The habitually India-phobic ex-England captain Mike Atherton wrote, "The consequences (of IPL), in terms of the finances and structure of the world game, are likely to be far-reaching." Former India Test opener Arun Lal, one of a team that had proposed a similar league to BCCI in 1997, says, "This is the future of Indian cricket. You can't stop it... The market demands and the market decides. It's all economics."

It may well look like that, but this is the economics of Indian cricket which is usually half-mirage, half-lottery.

AP PHOTO: AMAN CHANDRA



Sourav Ganguly



Rahul Dravid

"What happens in Indian cricket is not normal economics, it's not even economics. It's pure speculation," says a consultant on one of the IPL bids.

What IPL intends to do is transform the very nature of the Indian cricket watcher using the narcotic of T20 cricket and the razzle-dazzle of Bollywood to turn him from a national supporter to a local fan. Harish Thawani, chairman, Nimbus Communications Limited, which owns telecast right to all India's home cricket, says, "Cricket has always had a support base on the lines of nations, it will be intriguing to see how fast IPL can get a supporter base behind cities." IPL will ask enough searching questions of all its stakeholders. About the individual franchises' brand-building capacity, television's propensity to turn a profit from anything in cricket and BCCI's ability to deliver on its most ambitious project yet.

WHAT'S IN IT FOR THE OWNERS?

To start with, acres of attention and piling costs. The franchises are a heady, telegenic cocktail of business and glamour. The presence of the movie stars will serve to give the teams some traction with locals while it is their business backers (like the Wadia, Burman and Paul clan behind Zinta or the presence of Jai Mehta along with Shah Rukh Khan) who will have to do the running.

Apart from the initial fee of Rs 36 crore per franchise per year, the annual operating costs to run an IPL campaign are expected to be in the range of Rs 40-50 crore. The franchises will also receive a share of media rights sales, title sponsorship and ground signage earnings (see box). Their additional income will come from team shirt sponsors, 12 signs out of 72 in their home ground, ticket sales (at best Rs 50 lakh per game, adding up to Rs 3.5 crore per IPL season) and team merchandising, but profits are not expected in the first few years.

IPL though is not about profits or even about cricket, says Samir Kale,

AP PHOTO: TAY SINGH

THE OWNERS



MUKESH AMBANI

Rs 447 crore for Mumbai

PT PHOTO



VIJAY MALLYA

Rs 446 crore for Bangalore

DECCAN CHRONICLE

Rs 428 crore for Hyderabad

INDIA CEMENTS

Rs 364 crore for Chennai

GMR HOLDINGS

Rs 336 crore for Delhi

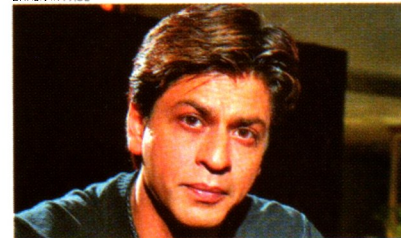
PT PHOTO



PREITY ZINTA, NESS WADIA

Rs 304 crore for Mohali

BHASKAR PAUL



SHAH RUKH KHAN

Rs 300 crore for Kolkata

EMERGING MEDIA

Rs 268 crore for Jaipur